style association football or listen to the latest K-pop hit. A multi-ethnic global society is forming over and above the individual states. Entrepreneurs, engineers, bankers and scholars throughout the world speak the same language and share similar views and interests.

Most importantly, the 200 states increasingly share the same global problems. Intercontinental ballistic missiles and atom bombs recognize no borders, and no nation can prevent nuclear war by itself. Climate change, too, threatens the prosperity and survival of all humans, and no government can single-handedly stop global warming.

An even greater challenge is posed by new technologies such as bioengineering and artificial intelligence. As we shall see in the last chapter, these technologies could be used to reengineer not just our weapons and vehicles, but even our bodies and minds. Indeed, they could be used to create completely new types of life forms and change the future course of evolution. Who will decide what to do with such divine powers of creation?

It is unlikely that humankind can deal with these challenges without global cooperation. It remains to be seen how such cooperation could be secured. Perhaps global cooperation can only be secured through violent clashes and the imposition of a new conquering empire. Perhaps humans could find a more peaceful way to unite. For 2,500 years since Cyrus the Great, numerous empires have promised to build a universal political order for the benefit of all humans. They all lied, and they all failed. No empire was truly universal, and no empire really served the benefit of all humans. Will a future empire do better?